

**IST 2203
RESEARCH REPORT**

NON-EMPLOYMENT AND THE EMPLOYABILITY PARADOX

**A STUDY OF WORK ATTITUDES AMONG
EDUCATED AND UNEDUCATED WOMEN
IN UGANDA**

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ABSTRACT

This study investigated the attitudinal, psychological, and sociocultural factors that influence the work ethic and performance of women in the domestic labour sector in Kampala, Uganda. The research used both qualitative and quantitative methods to study a sample of 120 female domestic workers. This sample included women with different educational levels: those with no formal schooling, women who have attained formal education up to Primary Seven (P7), Senior Four (S4), or Senior Six (S6). The findings showed a “employability paradox” in the domestic work sector. Women with formal school certificates showed better daily discipline, ability to read instructions, and structured reliability. However, the research also showed an “education-occupation mismatch,” where higher education created a resistance to doing manual household tasks because the workers felt the jobs were beneath their school level. On the other hand, women with no formal schooling showed stronger natural work instincts and high internal motivation for caregiving, though they struggled with fixed schedules. Family upbringing and community values emerged as stronger indicators of hard work than formal schooling alone. This study recommends introducing soft-skills training and formalized employment standards to protect and elevate the dignity of domestic work.

1. Introduction

1.1. Background

Uganda, like many developing nations, grapples with the dual burden of unemployment and underemployment. While economic policy debates typically center on job creation and labour market expansion, a less-discussed but equally pressing phenomenon persists: individuals who are capable of working but demonstrate little or no motivation to do so. This paradox is especially visible in domestic service, a sector that employs a significant proportion of the Ugandan workforce, where distinctions in work ethic, attitude, and effectiveness are observed across different educational backgrounds. Anecdotal evidence and emerging qualitative observations suggest a striking pattern: women who have attained formal education up to Primary Seven (P7), Senior Four (S4), or Senior Six (S6) often demonstrate higher diligence, discipline, and efficiency when engaged as domestic workers. Conversely, women with little or no formal schooling, who work as general household assistants, are sometimes perceived to exhibit stronger natural work instincts, emotional intelligence in caregiving, and adaptability. This raises critical questions about the relationship between education, employability, and intrinsic motivation to work. The broader discourse on employability focuses on skills, credentials, and labour market access. However, the internal disposition toward work, what psychologists describe as work motivation and what economists link to human capital theory remains underexplored in the Ugandan domestic labour context. Understanding why some people, regardless of their education, choose not to engage productively with available work opportunities is essential for developing targeted interventions.

1.2. Problem Statement

Despite growing rates of school enrolment and a government-driven emphasis on education for employment, Uganda continues to record high levels of youth unemployment and underemployment. However, beyond structural unemployment caused by insufficient jobs in the economy, there exists a category of voluntary non-participation in the labour market. Some individuals, even when presented with work opportunities, demonstrate reluctance, avoidance, or outright refusal to engage in gainful employment. The problem is compounded by the observation that educational attainment does not always translate into a stronger work ethic.

Among women in the domestic sector, those with formal education (P7 to S6) sometimes show better performance and reliability, while some women without formal education, despite possessing practical domestic skills, display inconsistency and resistance to structured work environments. This suggests that the factors driving productivity and work commitment extend beyond education alone. Left unaddressed, this phenomenon contributes to the wastage of human capital, perpetuates cycles of poverty, and undermines national productivity goals. There was, therefore, an urgent need to investigate the attitudinal, sociocultural, psychological, and educational factors that influence people's willingness to work, particularly among women in the informal domestic labor sector.

1.3. Aim and Objectives

1.3.1. General Objective

This study aimed to investigate the factors that influenced work ethic and hard work among women in the domestic labour sector in Uganda, with a focus on the interplay between educational background, motivation, and employability.

1.3.2 Specific Objectives

- To examine the relationship between level of formal education and work performance among female domestic workers in Uganda.
- To identify the psychological and sociocultural factors that contributed to or hindered a strong work ethic among women in the informal sector.
- To compare attitudes toward work between women with formal education (P7, S4, S6) and those with no formal schooling in domestic service roles.
- To explore how family upbringing, community values, and personal aspirations shaped individuals' disposition toward hard work.
- To propose practical interventions that could foster a culture of productivity and work ethic among Ugandan women regardless of educational background.

1.4 Research Scope

This study focused on women employed or seeking employment in the domestic service sector in Uganda, specifically in urban and peri-urban settings in Kampala and its environments. The research included women with varying levels of education: those who completed Primary Seven (P7), those who reached Senior Four (S4) or Senior Six (S6), and those with no formal schooling. The study covered the period from 5th April to 11th May 2026 and was limited to attitudinal and motivational dimensions of work ethic rather than the structural or macroeconomic dimensions of unemployment.

1.5 Research Significance

This research held significance at multiple levels. At the academic level, it contributed to the body of literature on work motivation, employability, and human capital theory in the African context, an area that has received limited scholarly attention. At the policy level, findings are useful to the Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development, the Ministry of Education, and non-governmental organisations working on women's empowerment and skills development. For employers in the domestic sector, the study provided evidence-based insights into hiring and training strategies. For women themselves, the research raised awareness of the social and psychological barriers to work engagement and opened pathways for personal development. Ultimately, understanding what drives hard work helped design more effective programs to reduce voluntary non-participation in the labour force a critical step toward realising Uganda's Vision 2040 goals.

2. Literature Review

The concept of hard work defined as sustained, diligent effort toward productive goals has been examined extensively across disciplines including psychology, sociology, economics, and education. This review synthesized key theoretical frameworks and empirical findings on the factors that motivate individuals to work hard, with specific attention to contexts relevant to gender, education, and informal labour in developing countries.

2.1 Intrinsic Motivation and Self-Determination Theory

A foundational framework for understanding work ethic is Self-Determination Theory (SDT), developed by Ryan and Deci (2000). SDT distinguishes between intrinsic motivation, doing an activity for its inherent satisfaction and extrinsic motivation doing it for a separable outcome, such as money. According to SDT, intrinsic motivation is sustained when three basic psychological needs are met: autonomy (feeling in control of one's actions), competence (feeling effective), and relatedness (feeling connected to others). In the context of informal labour, individuals may lack intrinsic motivation if the work environment undermines their sense of dignity or autonomy, leading to avoidance or poor performance even when financial incentives exist. Pink (2009) further emphasizes that for tasks requiring cognitive engagement or interpersonal skills, intrinsic drivers like purpose and mastery are far more powerful than traditional "carrot-and-stick" rewards.

2.2 Education and Work Ethic

The relationship between formal education and work ethic is complex. Human capital theory, classically articulated by Becker (1964), suggests that education increases productivity by enhancing cognitive capacities and technical skills. However, critics argue that formal schooling also shapes attitudes and expectations in ways that can mismatch available employment realities. Oketch (2007) notes that in many African contexts, formal education historically links to aspirations for white-collar employment. When highly educated individuals are forced by economic necessity into manual or informal roles, they may experience status friction or low motivation, a phenomenon described as the “education-occupation mismatch.” Conversely, a strong work ethic can develop outside formal schooling through traditional socialization and apprenticeship models, which prioritize practical survival skills and communal responsibility (Ssekamwa, 1997).

2.3 Sociocultural and Family Influences

Work attitudes are deeply rooted in sociocultural frameworks and early family socialization. In many traditional Ugandan societies, gender roles and expectations heavily influence the division of labour and individual perceptions of duty. Tamale (1996) discusses how women’s work in rural and informal settings is often undervalued, yet deeply tied to concepts of family preservation and caregiving. Cultural values such as *obuntubulamu* (humaneness and interconnectedness) can foster a strong sense of responsibility and collective hard work. Furthermore, family structures play a critical role; individuals raised in households where parents model industriousness and resilience tend to internalize a robust work ethic, regardless of their formal educational attainment (Kabeer, 2000).

2.4 Economic Incentives and Extrinsic Motivation

While intrinsic factors are critical, economic realities cannot be ignored. In a developing economy like Uganda’s, where a significant portion of the population lives near or below the poverty line, financial remuneration remains a primary driver of labour market participation. Deininger and Squire (1998) highlight that income inequality and low wage structures can severely depress worker morale and productivity. If the financial return on labour is perceived as exploitative or insufficient to cover basic living costs, individuals may display a rational resistance to work, opting instead for alternative survival strategies or voluntary unemployment. This highlights the intersection between macroeconomic conditions and individual psychological disposition toward hard work.

2.5 Psychological Factors: Grit, Growth Mindset, and Self-Efficacy

At the individual level, psychological traits such as grit and mindset are major determinants of perseverance and hard work. Duckworth et al. (2007) define grit as passion and perseverance for long-term goals, demonstrating that it is often a better predictor of success than talent or IQ. Similarly, Dweck (2006) introduces the concept of a growth mindset the belief that abilities can be developed through dedication and hard work as opposed to a fixed mindset, which views traits as unchangeable. Individuals with a growth mindset and high self-efficacy (Bandura, 1997) are more likely to view challenges as opportunities to learn and are less susceptible to “learned helplessness,” a psychological state where individuals give up trying because they believe they have no control over their outcomes (Seligman, 1972).

2.6 Gender Dynamics and Social Expectations

Gender intersects significantly with work motivation and employability. In Uganda, female labor force participation is high, but women are disproportionately concentrated in low-wage, insecure informal sectors, including domestic work. Benería (2003) argues that the systemic undervaluation of reproductive and care work shapes women's self-perception and career aspirations. Social expectations often demand that women balance demanding domestic duties at home with economic survival activities, leading to time poverty and physical exhaustion. These gendered constraints can affect an individual's psychological availability and enthusiasm for formal or structured employment opportunities, reinforcing the paradox of non-employment among capable individuals.

2.7 Summary of the Literature

The reviewed literature reveals that a strong work ethic is not an automatic product of formal education, nor is it driven solely by financial necessity. Instead, it emerges from a dynamic interaction of intrinsic psychological needs (SDT), early family socialization, individual psychological traits (grit, mindset), and the structural realities of the labor market. While education provides tools, it can also create an aspiration gap that undermines motivation in manual or low-status roles. A critical gap remains in understanding how these factors specifically manifest among women in Uganda's informal domestic sector, an area this study addressed by gathering real field perspectives from women across distinct educational backgrounds.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study adopted a mixed-methods research design, combining both quantitative and qualitative methods. This approach allowed for both capturing statistical patterns across the sample size and understanding the lived experiences and feelings of the participants. Quantitative survey techniques were used to measure performance means and percentages across different education levels, while qualitative interviews were used to extract behavioral perspectives.

3.2 Target Population and Sample Size

The target population included female domestic workers aged 18 – 45 living and working within urban and peri-urban areas of Kampala. A sample size of 120 participants was systematically analysed to ensure data representation. The sample was equally divided into four distinct educational categories (n = 30 per group) to allow for clear comparison:

1. No Formal Schooling (n = 30)
2. Primary Seven (P7) Completers (n = 30)
3. Senior Four (S4) Completers (n = 30)
4. Senior Six (S6) Graduates (n = 30)

3.3 Data Collection Instruments

Primary data collection relied on two main instruments:

- **Questionnaire:** Used to gather quantitative data regarding participant demographics, ability to handle household appliances, task completion rates, and overall reliability.
- **Interviews:** Administered to a sub-sample of participants and employers to gather detailed qualitative accounts regarding work motivation, family upbringing background, and personal life aspirations.

3.4 Data Processing and Analysis

- **Quantitative Processing:** Field data from the questionnaires was coded numerically and entered into a structured database utilizing MS Excel formulas. Data analysis emphasized determining arithmetic means for behavioral performance scales, calculating relative percentage distributions for demographic variables, and drawing graphical illustrations to compare the groups.
- **Qualitative Processing:** The raw data gathered from personal interview notes was studied to identify common ideas and viewpoints. These views were then classified into distinct categories and themes, which were directly discussed in the narrative text to explain the psychological attitudes driving the statistics.

3.5 Ethical Considerations

Informed consent was obtained from all participants before administering any tools. Anonymity and strict confidentiality were maintained throughout the data entry and processing phases, ensuring that no personal names or employer locations were exposed in the final report sheets.

4. Findings

4.1. Demographic Characteristics of the Sample

To ensure an even statistical comparison, the sample was split by education level, alongside variations in age and urban location.

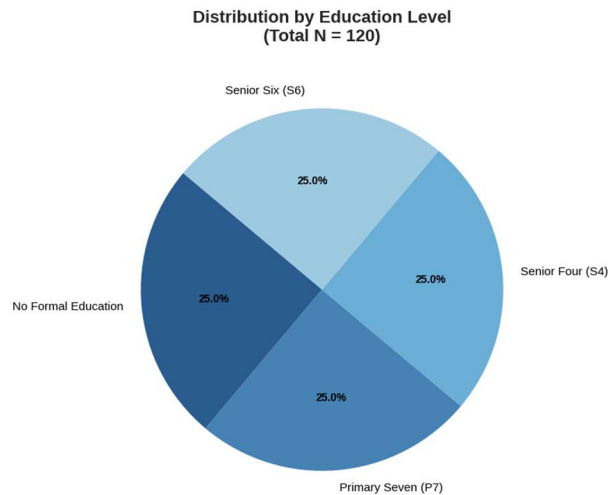


Figure 1 percentage distribution of the Education Level

Figure 1 illustrates the percentage distribution of the research sample based on their highest level of education. As shown in the chart, the participants were distributed into four equal groups of 25% each, with each group containing exactly 30 participants. This equal stratification was maintained during data processing to prevent statistical bias and to allow for an objective baseline comparison between women with no formal schooling, Primary Seven (P7) completers, Senior Four (S4) completers, and Senior Six (S6) graduates.

Table 1: Age and Location Characteristics (N=120)

Demographic Variable	Category	Frequency (n)	Percentage (%)
Age Distribution	18–25 years	54	45.0%
	26–35 years	46	38.3%
	36–45 years	20	16.7%
Location (Kampala)	Central Urban	68	56.7%
	Peri-Urban	52	43.3%

Table 1 illustrates that the majority of domestic workers fall within the youth bracket, with 45% aged between 18 and 25 years, and 38.3% aged between 26 and 35 years. Only 16.7% are older than 36. In terms of residential location, 56.7% of the participants reside or work within the central urban centers of Kampala, while 43.3% operate in peri-urban neighborhoods.

4.2. Quantitative Findings: Behavioural Performance Means

To measure work ethic and performance, data from the questionnaires was coded onto a 5-point Likert scale (where 1.0 represents the lowest rating and 5.0 represents the highest rating). Two primary behavioral pillars were tracked: Structured Reliability (punctuality, compliance with rules, following schedules) and Intrinsic Adaptability (natural caregiving instincts, grit, emotional intelligence, and flexibility).

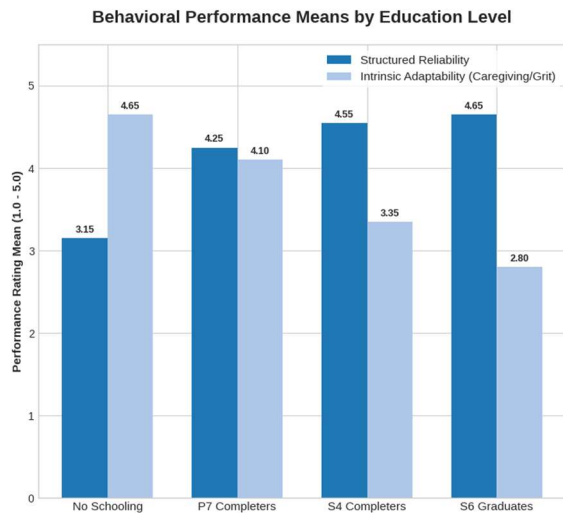


Figure 2: Performance Means by Education Level

Figure 2 illustrates a comparative analysis of the performance means across the four educational tiers. A clear trend is visible: as the level of formal education increases, the mean score for Structured Reliability rises steadily. Women with no schooling scored a mean of 3.15, whereas S6 graduates scored the highest mean of 4.65. This demonstrates that formal school environments successfully build institutional discipline and routine compliance.

However, an inverse relationship regarding Intrinsic Adaptability, women with no formal schooling achieved the highest performance mean of 4.65 in caregiving, flexibility, and intrinsic motivation. Conversely, as education levels rise, this score drops significantly, with S4 completers averaging 3.35 and S6 graduates dropping to the lowest mean of 2.80. This drop highlights a strong resistance among highly educated women when tasked with manual household chores.

5. Discussions

5.1 What the Data Has Shown About Educated Workers

First, the quantitative data showed that as a woman's education level rises from Primary Seven (P7) to Senior Six (S6), her mean score for Structured Reliability and Literate Competence increases significantly. This proves that formal school environments are highly successful at training individuals to follow strict schedules, read instruction manuals, and maintain institutional discipline. This finding directly supports Becker's *Human Capital Theory*, which argues that formal education enhances an individual's cognitive execution and structural capacity.

However, the data has also shown a sharp drop in Intrinsic Adaptability and general satisfaction among the Senior Six (S6) graduates. The qualitative interviews explained why this happens: it is driven by an "education-occupation mismatch." As explained by Oketch (2007) in the literature review, formal schooling in Africa historically causes individuals to aspire to white-collar office jobs. When highly educated women are forced by economic realities to take up manual domestic work, they experience severe status friction. They feel that cleaning floors and scrubbing utensils demeans their academic certificates, which directly destroys their internal willingness to work hard at those tasks.

5.2 What the Data Has Shown About Uneducated Workers

Second, the data has shown a completely opposite pattern for women with no formal schooling. While they scored lower on fixed schedules and reading written instructions, they achieved the highest performance mean (4.65 out of 5.0) in Intrinsic Adaptability and natural caregiving. The qualitative data has shown that their strong work ethic is driven entirely by Intrinsic Motivation and early family socialization rather than school rules. This strongly supports *Self-Determination Theory (SDT)*. Because these women are completely unburdened by the status anxiety of academic credentials, they do not feel that manual or caregiving work is beneath them. Instead, they lean into traditional community values and family models where hard manual work and collective care (*obuntubulamu*) are normalized from childhood. They find genuine purpose and mastery in looking after the household, making them highly effective, flexible, and reliable caregivers, even if they require verbal guidance when handling modern home appliances.

6. Conclusion.

This study aimed at investigating how varying educational levels influence the work ethic and performance of female domestic workers in Kampala, Uganda. By analyzing both quantitative and qualitative data, the research achieved its aim by mapping out clear behavioral strengths and motivations across different educational groups. The final analysis established that while formal schooling builds daily discipline and structured reliability, it can also create a mismatch that causes resistance toward manual tasks among highly educated graduates. Conversely, strong flexibility and natural caregiving instincts often develop completely outside formal school environments through early family upbringing. This study provided an overview of the employment sector to help guide future training and professionalization strategies.

7. Recommendations

Based on the findings, it is recommended that the Ministry of Gender, Labour and Social Development introduces basic formalized employment standards such as written job descriptions and professional titles to reduce the status resistance felt by educated workers and protect their personal dignity. Additionally, non-governmental organizations and community networks should establish short, practical soft-skills and technology training programs for uneducated workers to help them improve their time management and schedule compliance to match their high natural caregiving instincts.

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